

Reef fish

Coral reefs teem with an incredible variety of fish. Many are brightly colored, helping them to find each other or scare away predators. Some swim in schools as they nibble the corals, or sift particles from the water. Others live alone, hiding in the crevices in the reef. There are also some remarkable looking reef fish that rely on camouflage or venomous defenses to protect them from predators.

Butterflyfish

Escape artists

Length Up to 12 in (30 cm)

Range Atlantic, Pacific, and Indian oceans

Diet Corals, worms, and plankton

Many reef fish have short, flattened bodies that enable them to dive into narrow gaps between the corals if they are attacked by predators. They include this butterflyfish, which uses its narrow snout to pick at corals, and extract small worms and other animals from crevices in the reef.



Angelfish

Dazzling colors



Length Up to 24 in (60 cm)

Range All tropical seas

Diet Mainly small animals

Angelfish are among the most colorful and vividly patterned of all coral reef fish, and some even change their colors and patterns as they grow. They are similar to butterflyfish, but often bigger. Found alone or in pairs, angelfish feed on tiny drifting plankton and plantlike animals such as sponges and sea squirts that cling to the reef among the corals.

Surgeonfish

Busy schools

Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)

Range All tropical seas

Diet Algae

Big schools of surgeonfish swim among the reef corals searching for food. They are herbivores that use their small teeth to nibble at tiny seaweeds and other algae. A surgeonfish gets its name from the bladelike spines on each side of its tail, which are as sharp as a surgeon's scalpel.



Barracuda

Hot pursuit



Length Up to 6.5 ft (2 m)

Range All tropical seas

Diet Fish

Small fish swimming in open water are chased and caught by hunters such as barracudas, wrasses, groupers, and trevallies. Barracudas in particular are sleek, powerful killers that launch high-speed attacks on schooling fish, ripping them to pieces with their extremely sharp teeth.

